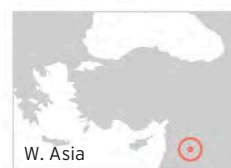




Palmyra

An ancient caravan oasis, which became a vital crossroads on the trade route from China, India, and Persia to the Roman Empire



△ ROMAN THEATER

The 2nd-century theater stands in a semicircular piazza off the main colonnaded street. It has been a focal point of the city since its restoration in the mid-20th century.

The city of Palmyra was built on the site of a remote oasis in the Syrian desert, which had been known for millennia as a stopping place for caravans. It had its heyday, however, when it was part of the Roman province of Syria in the 1st and 2nd centuries CE and became an important trading center.

A meeting of cultures

The local population was Semitic with a well-established cultural tradition, and they were given a large degree of autonomy under Roman rule. This resulted in a synthesis

of cultures, reflected in the architecture of the city. A wide colonnaded avenue in the Classical style ran through the center of the city, flanked by residential streets. Within the city walls, there were also the public buildings typical of a Roman town, alongside temples to the local deities. To the west of the city were the necropolises to house the dead.

Despite destructive onslaughts through the ages, many of the finest structures had survived into the 21st century, but during the Syrian Civil War, some buildings were damaged, and in 2015, Islamic State militants tragically demolished many of the remaining monuments.